

The apron of the 10th Degree is white, lined, edged and fringed with black; the flap also is black. In the center are painted or embroidered three gates, and over each gate is a rosette representing the three assassins of Hiram as well as those vices against which Masonry is particularly opposed.

The cordon is a broad watered black ribbon, worn from right to left; on the front of which are embroidered three rosettes bearing the same symbolism as those on the apron.

The jewel is a dagger, its hilt gold and its blade silver; it hangs from the end of the cordon.

DUTIES

To enlighten our souls and minds. To instruct and enlighten the people. To be vigilant to the interests and honor of our country. Be tolerant and liberal. War against fanaticism and persecution with education and enlightenment.

LESSONS

Ignorance is the principal enemy of human freedom. A free press is indispensable to true liberty. Remorse and guilt are God's punishment and more severe than that of man. Ambition creates tyranny and despotism. Fanaticism creates intolerance and persecution.

FOR REFLECTION

Do principles shape and control your conduct or are you guided by sentiment? Are you tolerant even of intolerance?

IMPORTANT SYMBOLS

The assassin Abairam, the cave with a pale light and fountain, the stranger Pharos, the Master Hiram as Human Freedom.

For those who have received their initial Masonic instruction in a Symbolic Lodge where the assassins are executed in the 3rd Degree, the drama of the Elu of the Nine and Elu of the Fifteen may be confusing. The Scottish Rite degrees differ markedly from those of the York Rite Symbolic Lodge with respect to this portion of the allegory. The assassins are not apprehended in the Master's Degree but in the 9th and 10th Degrees.

The word "Elu" which appears in this and following degrees is a French word meaning "elect" and refers to those chosen or elected to find and inflict punishment upon the three assassins. "Elect" was also a term used by the Gnostics. It defined someone who was in possession of the "gnosis" or divine knowledge acquired by revelation.

CEREMONY

In a Chapter of the Elu of the Nine the traditional hangings are black, strewn with silver tears to remind us of the death of Hiram. In addition, alternating red and white columns appear on the hangings. This is one of the first symbols clearly derived from the Kabbalah, a Jewish mystical philosophy. The red columns represent severity, or the trials of the Hebrews; the white columns represent mercy, or the return of the Jews to the folds of God's grace. They alternate to portray the cyclical nature of these periods in Hebrew history. The

Lodge of Elu of the Fifteen traditionally represents the Audience Chamber of King Solomon. The hangings are black with red and silver tears. There are three sets of five lights, four forming a square with one in the center; the wax is yellow, meaning knowledge and also, as the color of the sun, represents the Deity. These two degrees are conferred together, because they relate a single tale: the fate of the assassins of our Grand Master Hiram Abif.

In the first part the principal characters in the story are a stranger from Joppa named Pharos, and Jubelum (who was also called Abairam), one of the assassins.

As the drama begins, Pharos, a poor herdsman from Joppa, is searching for stray animals in the hills when he sees three men enter a cave. He hides. The third assassin, known as Jubelum, appears and presents a somber soliloquy on the remorse and guilt he feels having killed Hiram:

'Twas I who struck the Master down, –'twas I did plot and plan his death and burial. 'Twas I, who with devilish cunning conceived to plant acacia to hide his grave.

Alas, my cunning saved me not! And now in grief too great for human strength to bear in misery, disgrace, dishonor and despair. The food of beasts I've had to eat or starve, And on such loathsome stuff I've lived some months, as measured by the sun, but, if you count the time of suffering, eternity were not enough to measure all my woe.

But, no, 'tis God's own way of punishing, to leave intact the minds of guilty men, 'Tis greater pain than a thousand deaths to let the conscience work and prey upon the mind.

Satolkin and Yehu–Aber, who is represented by the candidate, enter. In the interim King Solomon is supposed to have elected nine Brethren to seek the assassins of our Grand Master Hiram Abif. In this scene Satolkin and Yehu–Aber, having lost their companions in the darkness, discover a cave in the mountains. In the cave they see one lamp on the floor, water flowing as if from a

fountain and a man asleep. The candidate is told to arm himself and if the sleeping man awakes, strike at his head and heart. The stranger stumbles and falls, waking the sleeping man who attacks the candidate with a dagger. The stranger enters the combat and yells, “Nakum” (vengeance). The assassin places his left hand on his head and then his heart and falls dead, killed by Yehu–Aber. The stranger then severs the assassin’s head. The lost brothers are found and together they return to Jerusalem.

Because the stranger shouts the Hebrew word for vengeance, this degree has been misunderstood as an allegorical vengeance degree seeking retribution for the fallen Templar Order. Illustrious Brother Mackey’s words should satisfy the concerned:

> *The word Nekam is used in Freemasonry in precisely the same sense in which it is employed by the Prophet Jeremiah (1, 15) when he speaks of nikemat Jehovah, the vengeance of the Lord—the punishment which God will inflict on evil–doers. The word is used symbolically to express the universally recognized doctrine that crime will inevitably be followed by its penal consequences. It is the dogma of all true religions; for if virtue and vice entailed the same result, there would be no incentive to the one and no restraint from the other (Vol. 2, p. 1079).*

Banaias introduces Pharos and the Elus into the audience chamber of King Solomon, and the tale of the assassin’s demise is recounted. Yehu–Aber and his companions are rewarded by being advanced in the Ancient Mysteries to the Order of the Nugah–Aur, a Hebrew word meaning “to bring forth the Light.”

Solomon, Hiram of Tyre and Banaias continue to lament the death of the Master Hiram, and the unsatisfied demands of justice. Ben–Dekar, an Elu of the Nine, reports to King Solomon that he has happened upon the two assassins in the land of Gath. The King prepares a written message to Makah, the ruler of Gath. He selects an additional six men to accompany the nine Elus who found the first assassin near the cave.

The candidate and some of his brothers go to the quarry near Gath. They see a group of workmen quit for the day and leave. Two workmen stay, taking seats on two stones; they are the assassins. One expresses his remorse at the murder of Hiram and says that he prays for the solace of a single hour of sleep. The other does not pray for sleep but fears it because of a terrifying dream. In his dream he is an innocent young boy walking with his mother, hands clasped together. His mother then becomes a monstrous spirit form hissing “Ingrate, shame of thy mother, graceless guilty son.”

The two assassins are captured alive and returned to King Solomon. Awaiting trial they are placed in a tower called “Akhiza,” probably deriving from the Hebrew word for “cruel” or “fierce,” Akzar (See, for example, Isaiah 13:9 and Jeremiah 50:42). They are found guilty, hanged and then decapitated. Along with that of Abairam, the first assassin, their heads are then set upon the east, west and south gates of the city.

The fifteen who participated in the capture of the assassins are rewarded by admittance into a higher degree of the Mysteries and a new order called the Elu of the Fifteen. The candidate, in being invested with this rank, devotes himself to toleration and liberality, by lighting the nine candles of yellow wax. Yellow is representative of the sun, hence light and knowledge. As each candle is lit, nine knightly virtues are verbalized: impartiality, courtesy, devotedness, firmness, frankness, generosity, self–denial, heroism and loyalty.

These are not, however, the principal duties of Elus. He dedicates himself to instructing and enlightening the people, thus freeing them from superstitious fears and subservience. Ignorance, which is symbolized by the third assassin, is the principal enemy of human freedom, figured in the Master Hiram. The stranger, Pharos, represents a free press, which with liberty and knowledge, helps to destroy ignorance. The cave is a symbol of the imprisonment of the human soul and intellect by ignorance, superstition, deceit and fraud. The lamp feebly lighting the cave reminds us of the pale light substituted by spiritual despotism in the human soul for the brilliant light of truth. The fountain

symbolizes the ignorance and fraud perpetrated by the priesthood in the past which even now flows into the present.

If the decapitation of the assassin in the cavern were not symbolical, the incident would have no place in Masonry, any more than the dagger and the odious word, “Vengeance.” The two assassins are symbols of the special enemies of freedom: ambition and fanaticism. Tyranny and despotism are born from ambition; intolerance and persecution spring from fanaticism. Combined with the symbolic meaning of Abairam from the 9th Degree, the three heads over the gates are symbolic of ignorance, ambition and fanaticism, particular enemies of freedom.

As is often common with allegories, the story of Hiram and the perfidious Fellowcrafts raises questions unanswered in the story itself. Because the 10th Degree officially closes the allegory of Hiram, it is appropriate to raise and answer a few questions.

1. Who were those Fellowcrafts?

We know that the Fellowcrafts were “hewers on the mountains and in the quarries,” and thus, only Master Masons actually worked on the Temple itself. Isn’t it strange that those fifteen hewers could be around the Temple construction so long they would know “that it was the daily custom of the Grand Master Hiram” to go into the Temple and view the work? Did they have some special assignment? Had they been injured? Of course the allegory had no need of such details to present its lessons, but such questions could provide the basis for an interesting Masonic short story.

2. What are the symbolic meanings of the attacks upon Hiram?

The presentations of the Symbolic Degrees do not explain the symbolism of the instruments used nor the reason for the places of injury. In subsequent Scottish Rite degrees these symbols are important and thus need to be explained.

Hiram is first accosted at the south gate of the Temple where the instrument of the attack is the rule. In Greek the word for a “rule,” whether a measuring instrument or a code of conduct, is canon. Thus we see the bureaucracy of the

early Church establishing the Canon Law to regulate conduct. This law was to be obeyed with unquestioned loyalty, hence it is an apt symbol of the suppression of freedom of speech which might question the divinity and justice of these laws; therefore Hiram, with the rule, is struck where the organs of speech are.

The instrument of attack at the west gate of the Temple was the square, an implement formed of two rigid pieces of metal at right angles to each other; it represents the merger of civil and religious power intending to control man's emotions, telling him not only what he can do but also what he can believe. Despotism, which history tells us results from this unholy merger of earthly powers, seeks to rule by dividing friends and relatives that none may unite against the tyranny. Thus Hiram is struck near the heart, the traditional seat of the affections.

The setting maul, an instrument of brute force, is a fitting symbol of the blind, unreasoning mob. It fears the force of the intellect and seeks the destruction of the products of the mind, banning plays, burning books, and murdering the finest men for the least of reasons. Hiram is killed at the east gate by a blow to the head, the seat of the intellect.

LECTURE

This degree's duties are among the most important in the Craft: education, enlightenment and patriotism. Education and enlightenment are not simply schooling and the worldly understanding that derives therefrom; these duties hearken us to far higher and nobler aspirations. We must learn to guard against all forms of tyranny, whether from the pulpit or the podium. We must enlighten our souls as well as our minds in order to do the work of Him that guides us, ministering to our own self–improvement and the welfare of our nation.

Pike opens his lecture with a recitation of those qualities which aid and support patriotism. He sums up the duties of this degree "in the simple mandate, "Protect the oppressed against the oppressor; and devote yourself to the honor and interests of your Country" (p. 149). He also notes the contrast of earthly

sentiments and worldly deeds and gives notice to the student of Masonry that here may be found the practical active virtue which distinguishes honorable men.

Masonry provides the principles which sentiment lacks and, therefore, gives permanent impressions of goodness that serve to improve the mass of the people.

The mission of Masonry is not to cause unrest in civil government but rather to support the statutes and administrators of lawful authority against the clamor of indecisive and tumultuous rebellion. Political power is a contract with the governed. An abuse of that power breaks the contract and the parties are no longer bound to it. Therefore, Masonry's teachings are a precarious balance between rightful, even if severe, government and the need to speak out against abusive misgovernment.

Education:

An intelligent people, informed of its rights, will soon come to know its power, and cannot long be oppressed; but if there be not a sound ... the elaborate ornaments at the top of the pyramid of society will be a wretched compensation for the want of solidity at the base (p. 153).

Enlightenment:

Most men have sentiments, but not principles. The former are temporary sensations, the latter permanent and controlling impressions of goodness and virtue. The former are general and involuntary, and do not rise to the character of virtue. Every one feels them. They flash up spontaneously in every heart. The latter are rules of action, and shape and control our conduct; and it is these that Masonry insists upon (p. 150).

Masonry is action, and not inertness. it requires its Initiates to WORK, actively and earnestly, for the benefit of their brethren, their country, and mankind. It is the patron of the oppressed, as it is the comforter and consoler of the unfortunate and wretched. ...It is the advocate of the common people in those things which concern the best interest of mankind. It hates insolent power and impudent

usurpation. It pities the poor, the sorrowing, the disconsolate; it endeavors to raise and improve the ignorant, the sunken, and the degraded (p. 152).

Forget not, therefore, to what you have devoted yourself in this Degree: defend weakness against strength, the friendless against the great, the oppressed against the oppressor! Be ever vigilant and watchful of the interests and honor of your country! and may the Grand Architect of the Universe give you that strength and wisdom which shall enable you well and faithfully to perform these high duties! (p. 159).

Patriotism:

Masonry teaches that all power is delegated for the good, and not for the injury of the People; and that, when it is perverted from the original purpose, the compact is broken, and the right ought to be resumed; that resistance to power usurped is not merely a duty which man owes to himself and to his neighbor, but a duty which he owes to his God, in asserting and maintaining the rank which He gave him in the creation (p. 155).

The wise and well–informed Mason will not fail to be the votary of Liberty and Justice. He will be ready to exert himself in their defence, wherever they exist. It cannot be a matter of indifference to him when his own liberty and that of other men, with whose merits and capacities he is acquainted, are involved in the event of the struggle to be made; but his attachment will be to the cause, as the cause of man; and not merely to the country (p. 156).

The true Mason identifies the honor of his country with his own. Nothing more conduces to the beauty and glory of one's country than the preservation against all enemies of its civil and religious liberty. The world will never willingly let die the names of those patriots who in her different ages have received upon their own breasts the blows aimed by insolent enemies at the bosom of their country (p. 156).

Not often is a country at war; nor can every one be allowed the privilege of offering his heart to the enemy's bullets. But in these patriotic labors of peace, in

preventing, remedying, and reforming evils, oppressions, wrongs, cruelties, and outrages, every Mason can unite; and every one can effect something, and share the honor and glory of the result (p. 158).

Pike, in the lecture of this degree, expands upon and includes within its lessons those qualities of education and enlightenment only hinted at in the lecture of the preceding degree. With them he adds the great duty of toleration and bids us to not impose our creeds, sincerely held, upon others equally sincere in their different opinions.

Because Masonry welcomes all men of whatever religion and thus practices toleration, the distinction between Masonry and religion needs to be made. Religion asserts authority, but Masonry counsels introspection and reflection on the great mysteries of the human condition. Masonry asserts no authority as to creeds, submits no prophets for judgment, offers no writings from God and reveals no divine truths beyond simple morality. It has no priesthood, demands no fixed tithe, dictates no sacraments and coerces no one with threats of eternal punishment beyond one's own conscience. It offers no Redeemer, teaches no dogma, demands no obedience except simple morality and courtesy and contends with no just government. Masonry is tolerant, even supportive, of the most diverse religious beliefs. Religion has often divided men, but Masonry reaffirms the brotherhood of man. If this is religion, it is only the most primitive kind and gives no reason for offense except by the power of its own virtues.

Education and Enlightenment:

Masonry is not a religion. He who makes of it a religious belief, falsifies and denaturalizes it. The Brahmin, the Jew, the Mahometan, the Catholic, the Protestant, each professing his peculiar religion, sanctioned by the laws, by time, and by climate, must needs retain it, and cannot have two religions; for the social and sacred laws adapted to the usages, manners, and prejudices of particular countries, are the work of men (p. 161).

But Masonry teaches, and has preserved in their purity, the cardinal tenets of the old primitive faith, which underlie and are the foundation of all religions. ... Masonry is the universal morality which is suitable to the inhabitants of every clime, to the man of every creed. It has taught no doctrines, except those truths that tend directly to the well–being of man ... (p. 161).

The natural work of Masonry is practical life; the use of all the faculties in their proper spheres, and for their natural function. Love of Truth, justice, and generosity as attributes of God, must appear in a life marked by these qualities; that is the only effectual ordinance of Masonry. ... the natural form of Masonry is goodness, morality, living a true, just, affectionate, self–faithful life, from the motive of a good man. It is loyal obedience to God's law (p. 162).

Masonry cannot in our age forsake the broad way of life. She must journey on in the open street, appear in the crowded square, and teach men by her deeds, her life more eloquent than any lips (p. 163).

[Masonry] *does require and expect every man of us to do something, within and according to his means; and there is no Mason who cannot do some thing, if not alone, then by combination and association* (p. 173).

If Masonry will but be true to her mission, and Masons to their promises and obligations ... if we will but give aid to what were once Masonry's great schemes for human improvement, not fitfully and spasmodically, but regularly and incessantly, ... then we may be sure that great results will be attained and a great work done. And then it will most surely be seen that Masonry is not effete or impotent, nor degenerated nor drooping to a fatal decay (p. 175).

Toleration:

Toleration [holds] that every other man has the same right to his opinion and faith that we have to ours;... (p. 160).

No true Mason scoffs at honest convictions and an ardent zeal in the cause of what one believes to be truth and justice. But he does absolutely deny the right of

any man to assume the prerogative of Deity, and condemn another's faith and opinions as deserving to be punished because heretical (pp. 160–161).

You find (good men] in all Christian sects, Protestant and Catholic, in all the great religious parties of the civilized world, among Buddhists, Mahometans, and Jews. They are kind fathers, generous citizens, unimpeachable in their business, beautiful in their daily lives. You see their Masonry in their work and in their play (p. 162).

...toleration is one of the chief duties of every good Mason, a component part of that charity without which we are mere hollow images of true Masons, mere sounding brass and tinkling cymbals [1 Corinthians 13:1] (p. 166).

Liberality:

...liberality (holds] that as no human being can with certainty say, in the clash and conflict of hostile faiths and creeds, what is truth, or that he is surely in possession of it, so every one should feel that it is quite possible that another equally honest and sincere with himself, and yet holding the contrary opinion, may himself be in possession of the truth, and that whatever one firmly and conscientiously believes, is truth, to him (p. 160).

The Mason does not sigh and weep, and make grimaces. He lives right on. If his life is, as whose is not, marked with errors, and with sins, he ploughs over the barren spot with his remorse, sows with new seed, and the old desert blossoms like a rose (p. 163).

What is truth to me is not truth to another. The same arguments and evidences that convince one mind make no impression on another. This difference is in men at their birth. No man is entitled positively to assert that he is right, where other men, equally intelligent and equally well–informed, hold directly the opposite opinion (p. 165).

No man is responsible for the rightness of his faith; but only for the uprightness of it (p. 166).